mushrooms. The following methods are used to increase their life.

(i) Freezing (ii) Drying
(iii) Canning (iv) Vacuum Cooling
(v) Gamma radiation and storing at 15°C.

23.6 Hydroponics

Hydroponics is the method of growing plants without soil, using mineral nutrient solutions in water. The containers are made of glass, metal or plastic. They range in size from small pots for individual plants to huge tank for large scale growing. It was demonstrated by a German Botanist Julius Von Sachs in 1980. Hydroponics is successfully employed for the commercial production of seedless cucumber and tomato. Plants are suspended with their roots submerged in water that contain plant nutrients. The roots absorb water and nutrients, but do not perform the anchoring function. Therefore, the plants must be mechanically supported from above.

Importance of hydroponics

(i) Conservation of water and nutrients.
(ii) Controlled plant growth.
(iii) In deserts and Arctic regions hydroponics can be an effective alternative method.

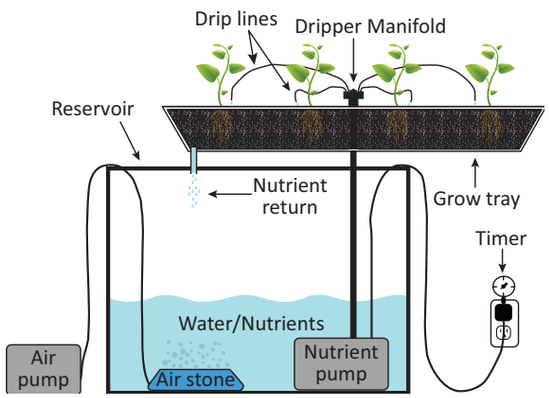


Figure 20.12 Hydroponics

23.7 Aeroponics

The aeroponic system is the high-tech type of hydroponic gardening. The growth medium in this type is primarily air. The roots hang in the air and are misted with nutrient solution. The misting is usually done for every few minutes, as roots will dry out rapidly if the misting cycles are interrupted. A timer controls the nutrient pump much like other types of hydroponic systems, except that the aeroponic system needs a short cycle timer that runs the pump for a few seconds every couple of minutes.

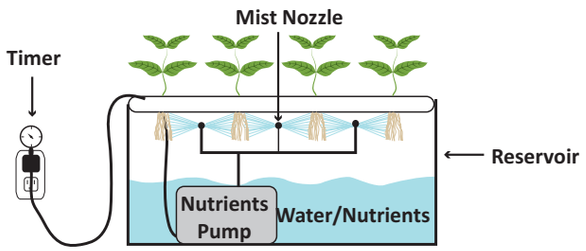


Figure 20.13 Aeroponics

23.8 Aquaponics

Aquaponics is a system of a combination of conventional aquaculture with hydroponics in a symbiotic environment, in which plants are fed with the aquatic animals' excreta or wastes. These wastes are broken down by nitrifying bacteria initially into nitrites and later into nitrates that are utilized by the plants as their nutrients. Thus, the wastes are utilized and water is recirculated back to the aquaculture system.

Aquaponics consists of two main parts, aquaculture- for raising aquatic animals like fish and hydroponics-for raising plants. Green leafy vegetables like chinese cabbage, lettuce, basil, coriander, parsley, spinach and vegetables like tomatoes, capsicum, chillies, bell peppers, sweet potato, cauliflower, broccoli and egg plant can be grown in aquaponics.



Figure 23.14 Aquaponics

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